U.S. History Big Picture Timeline

1. Pre-Columbian / Precolonial Era (before 1492)

- Indigenous civilizations across North America
- Complex societies: Mississippian, Pueblo, Iroquois Confederacy
- No European influence yet

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2. Age of Exploration & Early Contact (1492–1607)

- Columbus and subsequent European exploration
- Spanish, French, and English claims
- Early conflict, disease, and cultural exchange

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3. Colonial Era (1607–1763)

- Begins with Jamestown (1607)
- 13 British colonies develop
- Regional differences: New England, Middle, Southern
- Ends after the French and Indian War

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4. Revolutionary Era (1763–1789)

- Tensions after the French and Indian War
- American Revolution (1775–1783)
- Declaration of Independence (1776)
- Articles of Confederation → U.S. Constitution

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5. Early Republic (1789–1824)

- Washington → Monroe presidencies

- Political parties form
- Expansion begins
- Includes the War of 1812

Sub-period:

- **Era of Good Feelings (1817–1825)**
    - One-party dominance, nationalism

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6. Jacksonian Era (1824–1840s)

- Expansion of voting rights (for white men)
- Rise of populism under Andrew Jackson
- Indian Removal, spoils system

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7. Market Revolution & Reform Era (1820s–1850s)

- Industrial growth, transportation (canals, railroads)
- Second Great Awakening
- Reform movements: abolition, women's rights

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8. Sectionalism & Antebellum Era (1840s–1861)

- North vs. South tensions over slavery
- Westward expansion (Manifest Destiny)
- Leads directly to Civil War

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9. Civil War Era (1861–1865)

- American Civil War
- Union vs. Confederacy
- Ends slavery (13th Amendment)

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10. Reconstruction Era (1865–1877)

- Rebuilding the South
- Rights for formerly enslaved people (14th, 15th Amendments)
- Ends with Compromise of 1877

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11. Gilded Age (1877–1900)

- Rapid industrialization
- Big business, political corruption
- Massive immigration
- Wealth inequality

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12. Progressive Era (1890s–1920)

- Reform against Gilded Age excess
- Trust-busting, labor laws, women's suffrage
- Presidents: Roosevelt, Taft, Wilson

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13. World War I Era (1914–1918, U.S. in 1917–1918)

- World War I
- U.S. emerges as global power

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14. Roaring Twenties (1920–1929)

- Economic boom, cultural change
- Jazz Age, consumerism
- Ends with stock market crash

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15. Great Depression & New Deal (1929–1941)

- Economic collapse
- Franklin D. Roosevelt's New Deal programs

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16. World War II Era (1941–1945)

- World War II
- U.S. becomes a superpower

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17. Early Cold War Era (1945–1960s)

- Cold War begins
- Containment, nuclear tension
- Korean War

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18. Civil Rights Era (1950s–1960s)

- Movement for racial equality
- Civil Rights Movement
- Major legislation (1964, 1965)

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19. Vietnam & Social Upheaval (1960s–1975)

- Vietnam War
- Protests, counterculture

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20. Late Cold War / Conservative Resurgence (1970s–1991)

- Watergate, distrust in government
- Ronald Reagan era
- Ends with collapse of Soviet Union

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21. Post–Cold War Era (1991–2001)

- U.S. as sole superpower
- Globalization expands

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22. War on Terror Era (2001–2010s)

- September 11 attacks
- Wars in Afghanistan and Iraq

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23. Contemporary Era (2010s–Present)

- Polarization, tech dominance
- Global competition (China, etc.)
- Cultural and political shifts still unfolding
